

Your stomach can stretch to more than 20 times its size after eating.

The longitudinal muscle layer extends the length of the stomach.

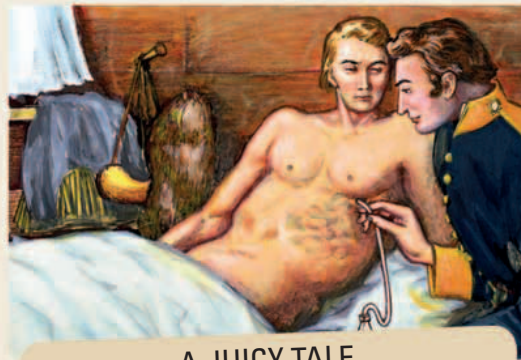
The circular muscle layer wraps around the stomach.

The oblique muscle layer runs diagonally around stomach.

► STOMACH LINING

This magnified view of the stomach's lining shows the openings of the glands that release digestive gastric juice into the stomach.

Gastric pit



A JUICY TALE

In 1822, fur trapper Alexis St. Martin accidentally shot himself in his side. This left a permanent opening to his stomach called a fistula. American army surgeon William Beaumont, who treated St. Martin, realized he could use his patient to find out how digestion in the stomach worked. Beaumont placed different types of food through the opening to see how fast they were digested. He also, as shown here, extracted gastric juice to investigate its composition and action on food.

WHAT MAKES YOU SICK?

Vomiting, or throwing up, happens when something irritates the lining of the stomach. This triggers the vomiting reflex. The diaphragm and abdominal muscles contract, squeezing the stomach so that food is forced up the esophagus and out of the mouth.

